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Home on the Cloud

In 2011, I was back in the States, working for the same nominal employer, Dell, but now attached to my old agency, the CIA. One mild spring day, I came home from my first day at the new job and was amused to notice: the house I'd moved into had a mailbox. It was nothing fancy, just one of those subdivided rectangles common to town house communities, but still, it made me smile. I hadn't had a mailbox in years, and hadn't ever checked this one. I might not even have registered its existence had it not been overflowing—stuffed to bursting with heaps of junk mail addressed to "Mr. Edward J. Snowden or Current Resident." The envelopes contained coupons and ad circulars for household products. Someone knew that I'd just moved in.

A memory surfaced from my childhood, a memory of checking the mail and finding a letter to my sister. Although I wanted to open it, my mother wouldn't let me.

I remember asking why. "Because," she said, "it's not addressed to you." She explained that opening mail intended for someone else, even if it was just a birthday card or a chain letter, wasn't a very nice thing to do. In fact, it was a crime.

I wanted to know what kind of crime. "A big one, buddy," my mother said. "A federal crime."

I stood in the parking lot, tore the envelopes in half, and carried them to the trash.

I had a new iPhone in the pocket of my new Ralph Lauren suit. I had new Burberry glasses. A new haircut. Keys to this new town house in Columbia, Maryland, the largest place I'd ever lived in, and the first place that really felt like mine. I was rich, or at least my friends thought so. I barely recognized myself.

I'd decided it was best to live in denial and just make some money, make life